

Exercise 1:

Read an interesting personal account written by a young boy who had moved back to Pakistan after years of living in Dubai. As you read it for the first time, underline any word that you find difficult to understand. Then try and guess the meanings yourself by finding clues from the context and finally look up the meanings of these words in the dictionary.

When my father told me that we would be shifting to Karachi, Pakistan, I didn't know how to react. As the day of departure loomed in front of me, my sentiments changed. Nostalgic memories of my past in Dubai started to linger in my mind. I was becoming homesick even though I was returning to my own country.

My first impressions of Pakistan were not the best. I was taken aback by the garbage everywhere, paan stains and insects all around. This was something I had never seen in Dubai.

For the first time, I felt like a stranger even though this was my home country. I was overcome by the loud buzzing of rickshaws, the hoards of people clinging on to the back bumper of a bus, and the bumpy roads that jerked and jostled me all the way home. There was a hustle and bustle in this huge city (Karachi) which I hadn't seen in Dubai.

I had always longed to stay with my relatives who were so loving and caring on our annual visits and now, since we had moved permanently, our home was swarmed by relatives. I couldn't remember being patted and kissed as much as I was that day, but the reality of Pakistan hit me when I began to speak to them. While speaking to them I had to explain myself in English, which was greeted by a few raised eyebrows. There was no doubt that I was welcomed but there was the feeling that I was less a Pakistani but more a 'pardesi'.

In many ways I lived a sheltered existence in Dubai. I had never seen drug addicts and beggars or even so many crippled people on the roads. In Pakistan I saw the reality of poverty for the first time. The pleas of people tapping windows and begging for a rupee were something that really bothered me. I felt an urge to do something to improve the situation. It was a significant experience as the sheltered idealist within me started to see the real world and the difficulties of everyday life.

Life in Dubai was easy. I never had to worry about the quality of water, the availability of electricity, cleanliness or inflation. But in Pakistan, these are daily concerns. I realized that you can't trust people to do their jobs, they have to be goaded, reminded and often bribed. After living in Karachi for six months, I am used to the social merry go around of weddings, parties and get togethers that have to be attended to maintain a footing in social circles.

I'm now accustomed to the daily water and electricity problems and surprisingly, I've learnt how to solve or rather temporarily fix the problem. These daily frustrations still trouble me but I am grateful for being exposed to a real society with real problems. There's a greater sense of freedom, belonging and community in your own country, sentiments that I had never acknowledged in my sheltered life in Dubai. In retrospect, living in Karachi has required an adjustment, a harsh reality check but what matters is that I've learned and become more in touch with the country I belong to.

Exercise 2:

Let us move on from guessing the meanings of individual words to guess the meaning of longer sentences. Here are three longer passages taken from the above account. Try and make sense as what the writer means when he expresses such sentiments. Then read the three more passages (a, b, & c) that follow and match each passage with its original one.

1. As the day of departure loomed in front of me, my sentiments changed. Nostalgic memories of my past in Dubai started to linger in my mind. I was becoming homesick even though I was returning to my own country.
2. For the first time, I felt like a stranger even though this was my home country. I was overcome by the loud buzzing of rickshaws, the hordes of people clinging on to the back bumper of a bus, and the bumpy roads that jerked and jostled me all the way home. There was a hustle and bustle in this huge city (Karachi) which I hadn't seen in Dubai.
3. I felt the urge to do something to improve the situation. It was a significant experience as the sheltered idealist within me started to see the real world and the difficulties of everyday life.

Now read these passages and match them with the above original ones:

- a. For me my native country appeared a bizarre place. I have never experienced such chaotic traffic, the crowds and the noise as I was driven home. This city is pulsating, full of life as compared to the quiet and peaceful Dubai.
- b. I wanted to do something helpful to improve the situation, but I was nervous because I have heard a lot of stories about how people cheat you. Nevertheless, for me living here was different because back in Dubai I lived a much more comfortable and protected life and here the problems made me realize how people struggle to live.
- c. The day I was to leave Dubai and board a plane for Karachi, I started to feel sad.